some orders. When he came to meet me in my office, there was a drawing of a turbine wheel on my table.

'Can you make a model of this?' I asked him.

Reddy took the drawing and studied it carefully for a few minutes. I knew it was a tough job, fabricating a model from a mere drawing. It may take a few months even if you got every reading right.

'It's just a drawing,' Reddy said.

I nodded.

'What if I need clarifications during fabrication?'

'Ask any of our engineers,' I said. 'They will give you the answers you need.'

Reddy did not ask any more questions, and left with a copy of the drawing.

A month later, Ravindra Reddy walked into my office again, this time with a giftwrap. It contained a beautiful one-to-one model of the turbine wheel that was just a drawing on my table a month ago. It was the first scale model of a part of the Vikas engine. I was impressed.

'You must have spent a lot of man hours and money on this,' I said appreciatively.

'Yes, but we did it not for money; only to show you that we can do it.'

This was one of the first lessons for ISRO that private participation should not just be allowed in the space programme, but encouraged actively to achieve our goals. While government institutions viewed private enterprises with skepticism, the base of our socialist bias being the notion that profit making is a sin, what went unacknowledged were not just the skills and efficiency of at least a section of private companies, but also their sense of belonging and the yearning for contribution for the nation's growth. First Andhra Sugars led by Thimmayya that set up our rocket fuel facility, and now MTAR Technologies were shining examples of this.

Years later, the fabricators of the ISRO spy case were to drag in the name of Ravindra Reddy, along with that of former Prime Minister P V Narasimha Rao's son Prabhakar Rao, exposing a conspiracy to stall India's